



Calmer Grooming

Building trust first, so grooming becomes something your dog can say "yes" to

For many dogs, grooming means being held still, loomed over and touched in sensitive places with strange tools. It's no surprise some dogs freeze, wriggle, mouth or growl. Groomer and behaviourist **Sue Williamson**, author of *Taking the Grrr out of Grooming Your Dog*, puts **trust before the task**: understanding grooming from the dog's point of view, watching their body language, and giving them a genuine choice.

Why grooming can be hard

- **Past experiences:** one frightening trim, or a tangle pulled too hard, can be remembered for a long time.
- **Feeling trapped:** being held, leaned over or put on a high table takes away the dog's ability to move away.
- **Sensitivity or pain:** a dog who dislikes being touched in one area may be sore there. A **vet check** is always worth it.
- **Too much, too fast:** long sessions fill the stress bucket, and the dog runs out of ways to cope.

Three principles

- 1. Observe.** Watch your dog's body language before, during and after every touch. Small signals tell you how they're really feeling.
- 2. Offer choice.** Your dog should always be free to move away. A dog who can leave is far more likely to stay.
- 3. Go slowly.** Little and often, stopping while your dog is still comfortable. Progress builds on calm, successful moments.

Ask first: the consent check



Every few strokes, **pause and ask**. If your dog stays relaxed or asks for more, carry on. If they move away, turn their head, lick their lips or go still, respect it. Take a break, or go back to something easier.

Respecting a "no" is what builds the trust that gets you more "yes".

Introducing the tools

Let your dog **sniff and investigate** each brush or comb on the floor first, and reward their interest. Begin with a **flat hand**, then the **back of the brush** or a soft mitt, before using bristles or teeth. Gentle TTouch-style circles with your fingertips can help a dog settle into being touched.

What you'll need

- A **non-slip mat** on the floor
- A **soft brush or grooming mitt** to start with
- The **brush and comb that suit your dog's coat**; ask your groomer
- **Rewards your dog loves**: treats, a lick mat or a toy
- Later: a **quiet** nail grinder or clippers



Grooming at Home, Step by Step

Start where your dog is comfortable, and build from there

WHERE TO START



Start here Build up Most sensitive

Most dogs are happiest being touched on the **shoulders, chest and sides**. Legs, neck and hindquarters come next. **Paws, face, ears, tail and rear end** are often the most sensitive, so leave them until your dog is relaxed elsewhere.

Every dog is different. Notice **where your dog tenses**, and treat those areas gently. They may be telling you something about comfort or pain.

Setting up for success

- **Groom on the floor** on a non-slip mat, rather than a high surface your dog can't leave.
- **Sit or kneel beside your dog**, side-on, rather than leaning over them.
- **No holding down**. If your dog needs restraining, the task is too big for today.
- **Little and often**: a minute or two, or one paw a day, is real progress.
- **Rewards your dog loves**: treats or a lick mat for some, a toy or game for others.

⚠ Signs to stop

Lip licking, yawning, turning the head away, whale eye, freezing, trying to leave, or **refusing a treat or toy they usually love**. Stop, give space, and next time make the step smaller. A growl is a warning, so **never punish it**.

A gentle routine

How often	What to do
Most days	A minute or two on one easy area, plus a few consent checks. Finish on a calm, happy note.
A few times a week	Brush through, then comb gently. If the comb catches, go back to the brush rather than pulling.
Weekly	A quick look at ears, eyes, pads and nails, using a light touch and lots of breaks.

Choosing a groomer

Look for a **low-stress or fear-free groomer**. Ask whether they offer short introductory visits, allow breaks, avoid restraint, and will let you share what works at home. A few **"happy visits"** with no grooming can make the salon a much less scary place.